

Put the Team Before Yourself: Investing in Others, Featuring Virginia Means

Virginia Means, Chief People Officer, United Distributors, Inc.

Coach Summitt said, “Teamwork is not a matter of persuading yourself and your colleagues to set aside personal ambitions for the greater good. It’s a matter of recognizing that your personal ambitions and the ambitions of the team are one and the same. That’s the incentive.”

Did you ever wonder what it would take to be one of the most respected leaders in your organization where people are energized by you and you are a pacesetter for team efficiency and success? Pat Summitt knew that every player on her team had a role to fill, a job to do. Without everyone’s full commitment, their team goals would never be accomplished.

In 1984, Pat faced a unique situation as she coached the U.S. Olympic team in Los Angeles. At the end of the Olympic trials, the final roster had to be at 12 players, which meant six players had to be cut. Pat decided to let the team cast confidential ballots to vote on the 12 players that should represent the United States at the Olympics. Incredibly, the player votes matched identically to the roster the coaches had made.

Even though this meant some players voted for others instead of themselves to have an Olympic opportunity, the final roster had a team full of superstars like Cheryl Miller, Anne Donovan, Lynette Woodard, and Denise Currie, none of whom were accustomed to sitting on the bench.

Pat decided the best approach was to tackle the situation head on. At the first team meeting, she announced, “Seven of you will be sitting on the bench when the game starts and seven of you will be on the bench when the game ends.”

Your team members work for your organization, but their satisfaction is tied directly to their relationship with you and with each other. Do you make investment in your people a priority? Do you show an interest in their interests? Do you embody putting the team before yourself?

And here’s the bottom line. Do they know you care? “No one cares how much you know until they know how much you care.” Sometimes, putting the team first is as simple as putting the team first.